

**THIS WAS
TOMORROW**
*IS THIS THE
FUTURE WE WERE
DREAMING OF?*

A PROJECT BY
ENRICO POLICARDO



Supported using public funding by
**ARTS COUNCIL
ENGLAND**

About the project

12 September - Open House Festival

Pollard Thomas Edwards - 10 Years of New Ground
Diespeker Wharf, 38 Graham Street
London N1 8JX

12 - 20 September - Open House Festival

Hastings Commons, Hastings

20 September - Open House Festival

Cressingham Gardens, Lambeth, London SW2

Autumn 2026, dates tbc

Calder Valley Community Land Trust, Hebden Bridge
Two Up Two Down, Liverpool, autumn 2026, dates tbc

This Was Tomorrow: Is This the Future We Were Dreaming Of? is a series of exhibitions by artist and photographer Enrico Policardo, drawn from a year spent visiting community-led housing projects across England. Supported by Arts Council England, the work is shown as billboard-scale prints pasted directly onto walls, accompanied by recorded interviews with the people who live in these places. The first exhibitions open during Open House Festival in September 2026.

Between late 2025 and 2026, the Policardo visited a dozen communities across London, the south coast, Cornwall and the North and West of England: cohousing groups, community land trusts, self-build projects, co-operatives and off-grid settlements. In each, he photographed the site and recorded residents, asking everyone the same question - is this the future you were dreaming of?

The resulting exhibitions present large-format photographs, reduced through a bitmap process to a field of black and white dots and printed at billboard scale. The prints are pasted unframed onto walls, indoors and out, and left to weather

over the run of each show. No master file is kept: each print is generated again from the original photograph, so no two are identical and none can be reproduced.

The people who live in these places do not appear in the photographs. Their voices carry the human account instead. A QR code beside each print opens an audio page on the project website, and visitors listen through their own headphones. Image and sound are never paired to explain one another, and the connection between them is left for the viewer to make.

The exhibitions are cross-pollinated: each community is shown alongside photographs of the others, so that a Cornish quarry appears in London and a London estate appears in Yorkshire. Many of these groups have worked for years without knowing that comparable projects exist elsewhere.

Alongside the exhibitions, the project website thiswastomorrow.co.uk holds a page for each community - photographs, the full recordings, an account of the visit, the history of the place and further reading - together with a generator that draws quotes at random from across the interviews.

Image and sound are never paired to explain one another. The gap between them is deliberate: what the viewer has to supply - imagining the people back into the spaces they have made - is the work.

Communities documented include Granby Four Streets and Two Up Two Down in Liverpool, OWCH / New Ground in Barnet, Cressingham Gardens in Lambeth, LILAC in Leeds, Calder Valley Community Land Trust in Hebden Bridge, Hastings Commons, Tinker's Bubble in Somerset, and Trevone Quarry, Kesoberi and Treneere in Cornwall.



Enrico Policardo, *This Was Tomorrow*, 2026. Bitmap print. Courtesy of the artist.

About the artist

Enrico Policardo (b. 1982, Gorizia, Italy) is a photographer and artist based in London. His work examines how systems of power organise everyday life and who gets to shape it - housing, the consumer economy, identity and borders, and the ways people make community. He is Creative Director of ReThinkable Festival on the Italy-Slovenia border (Nova Gorica / Gorizia, European Capital of Culture 2024-2026) and an Affiliate Research Fellow at the University of Nova Gorica. *This Was Tomorrow* began in 2022 with architectural historian Judith Martin, documenting endangered council estates in London, and took its present form following a residency at ESAD IDEA in Porto.

Supported by

Arts Council England. With the support of Simon Vickery (Open House Festival Programme Manager, Open City), writer and photographer Thaddeus Zupancic (London Estates: Modernist Council Housing 1946-1981), and architectural historian Judith Martin, co-author of the original *This Was Tomorrow* publication.

Press enquiries

For contacts and further info please write and email to info@enricopolicardo.com or visit thiswastomorrow.co.uk / enricopolicardo.com

Press images available on request.

IS THIS THE FUTURE WE WERE DREAMING OF ?

Home

Home isn't only a roof. It's community, living well, and a vision of the future that isn't the marry-mortgage-die structure most of us were handed. That's not a complaint, it's an acknowledgement of what nuclearising the family and selling false independence has done - a system built around the needs of capital rather than the needs of people. The real history of people, not the history of power written down as if it were the same thing, says the opposite: we have always come together, to get through hardship and to celebrate, to belong. That's the ordinary human thing. Not the fortified, defended, frightened version we're sold.

How the work is made

I work by subtraction. I take the people out of the photographs and keep their voices and words separate from the images. The person looking has to imagine them back in - from the sound, from a line said in the interview, from what the empty place suggests. The photographs are reduced to bitmap: no master file is kept, so each print is run again from the original and never comes out the same way twice. People are everywhere in this work. They're just not in the frame - they're around it.

Why

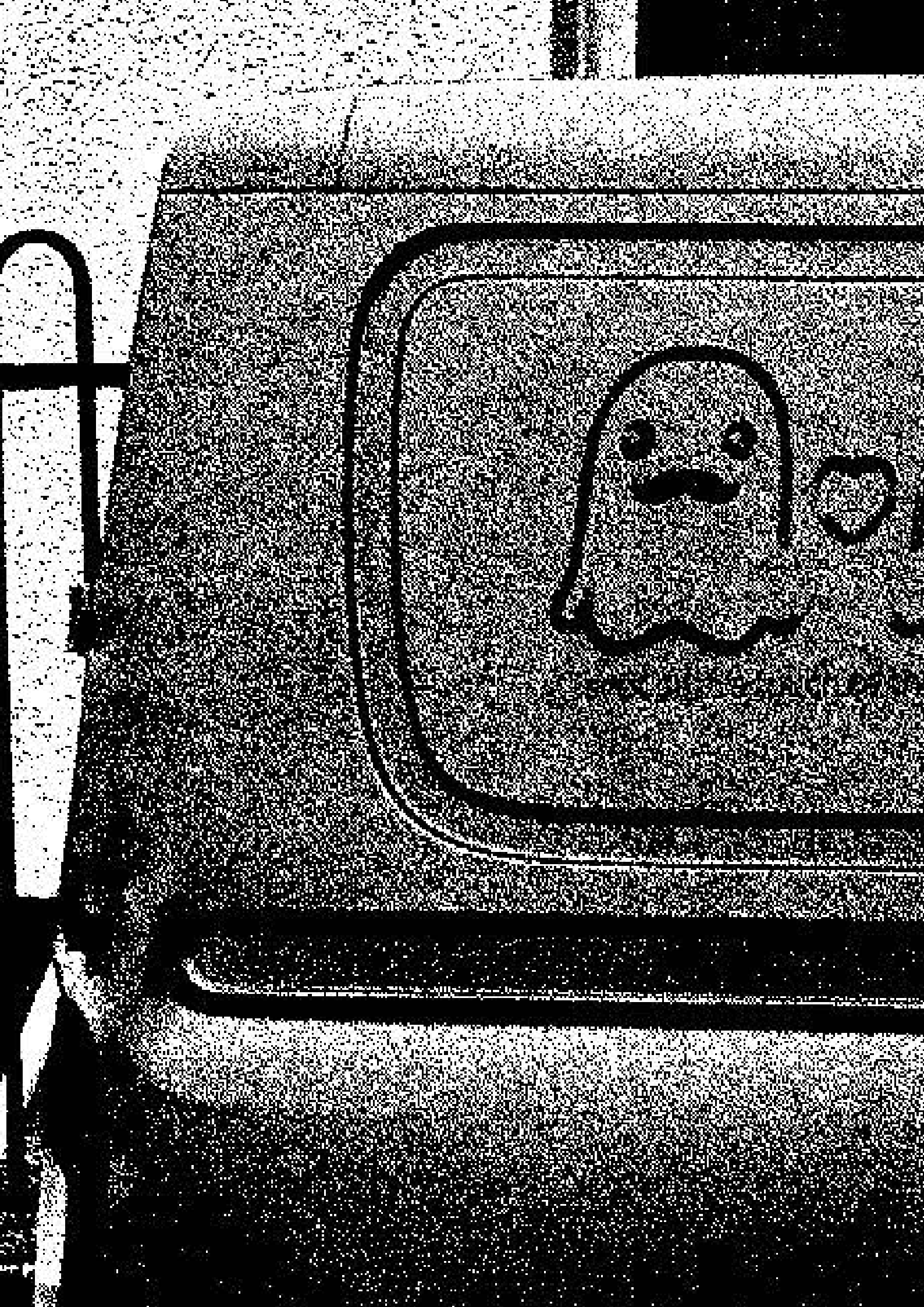
This work sits between documentary and something much more personal and abstract - a subjective reading of the places and people I visited. It's neither, and it's both, and I've stopped trying to resolve that.

What it's really about is imagination, and taking care of it. Removing the people is a way of forcing the viewer to build their own version of what's there - to do the work of picturing it, rather than being handed it. We're served so many images and so much information every day that the constant overstimulation leaves no room for our own imaginings. I wanted to make the opposite: large, quiet spaces to move through with the eye and the mind, room to speculate - what would I do here, what would it be to live like this, here or somewhere else.

It's the same reason I can't tidily call this art, or call it documentary. I don't much want to. My only real measure is whether it's inspiring - the way Adam Curtis moves between the informative, the poetic and the political, or the work of Jeremy Deller and Wolfgang Tillmans, all of whom I keep coming back to.

Enrico Policardo

London, 2026





A note

I made this project while living inside its own question - future-thinking and housing - which is proof enough that it isn't a speculative concern but a concrete one, urgent for me and my family as much as for a lot of people out there.

My hope is that you leave not with faith, and not with easy hope, but with the awareness that a different future isn't only possible - it's already been built.

My thanks go to everyone who has supported me through these years and kept my whole roaming existence going, and above all to my partner Rosamond, for the daily and unceasing support.

voices and places

Cressingham Gardens — Lambeth, London

**A post-war estate that resisted
Lambeth Council's 2015
demolition plans with its own
resident-authored People's Plan,
showing refurbishment was
deliverable for a fraction of the
cost of knocking it down.**

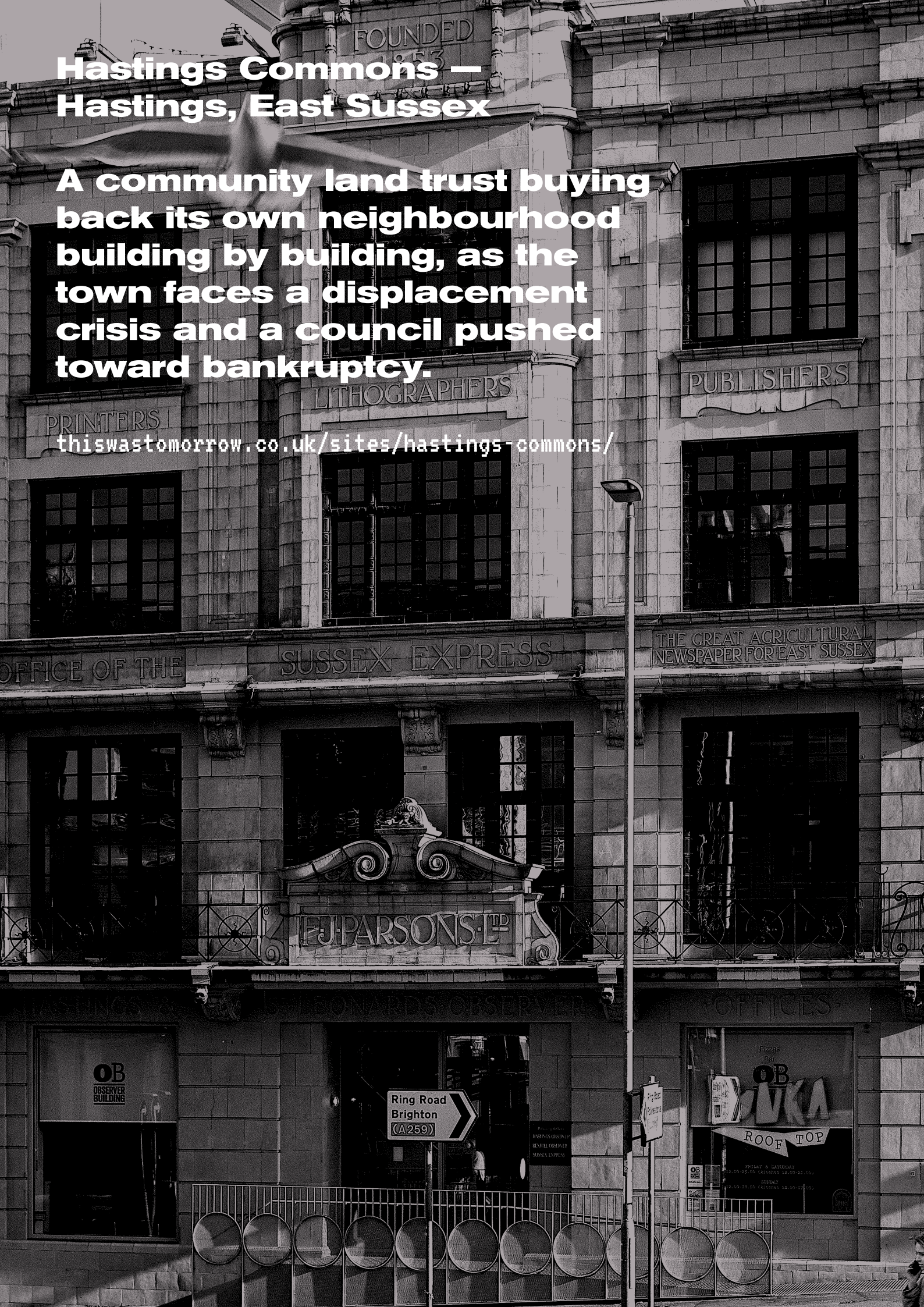
thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/cressingham-gardens

ROPERS WALK

Hastings Commons — Hastings, East Sussex

A community land trust buying back its own neighbourhood building by building, as the town faces a displacement crisis and a council pushed toward bankruptcy.

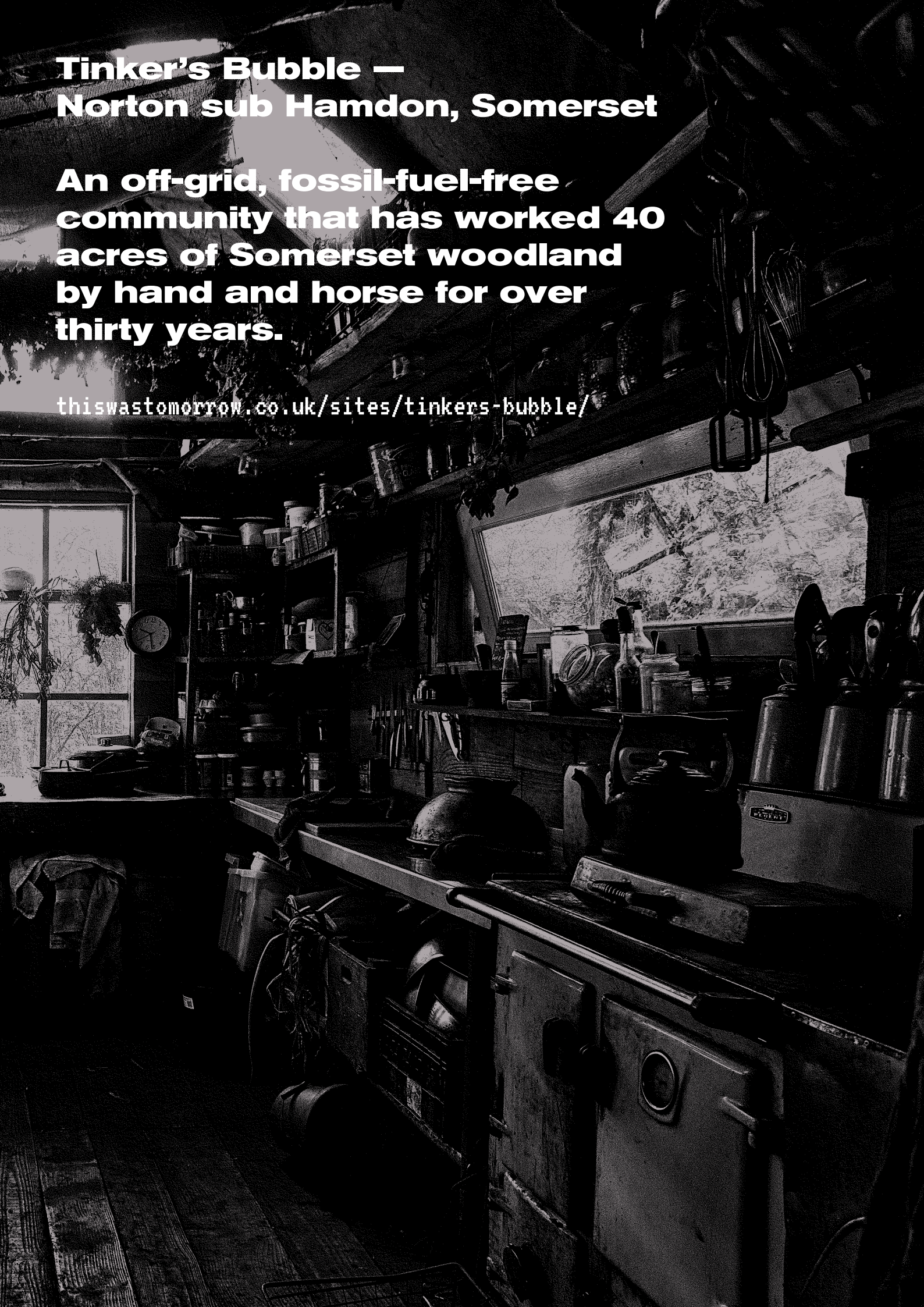
thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/hastings-commons/



Tinker's Bubble — Norton sub Hamdon, Somerset

**An off-grid, fossil-fuel-free
community that has worked 40
acres of Somerset woodland
by hand and horse for over
thirty years.**

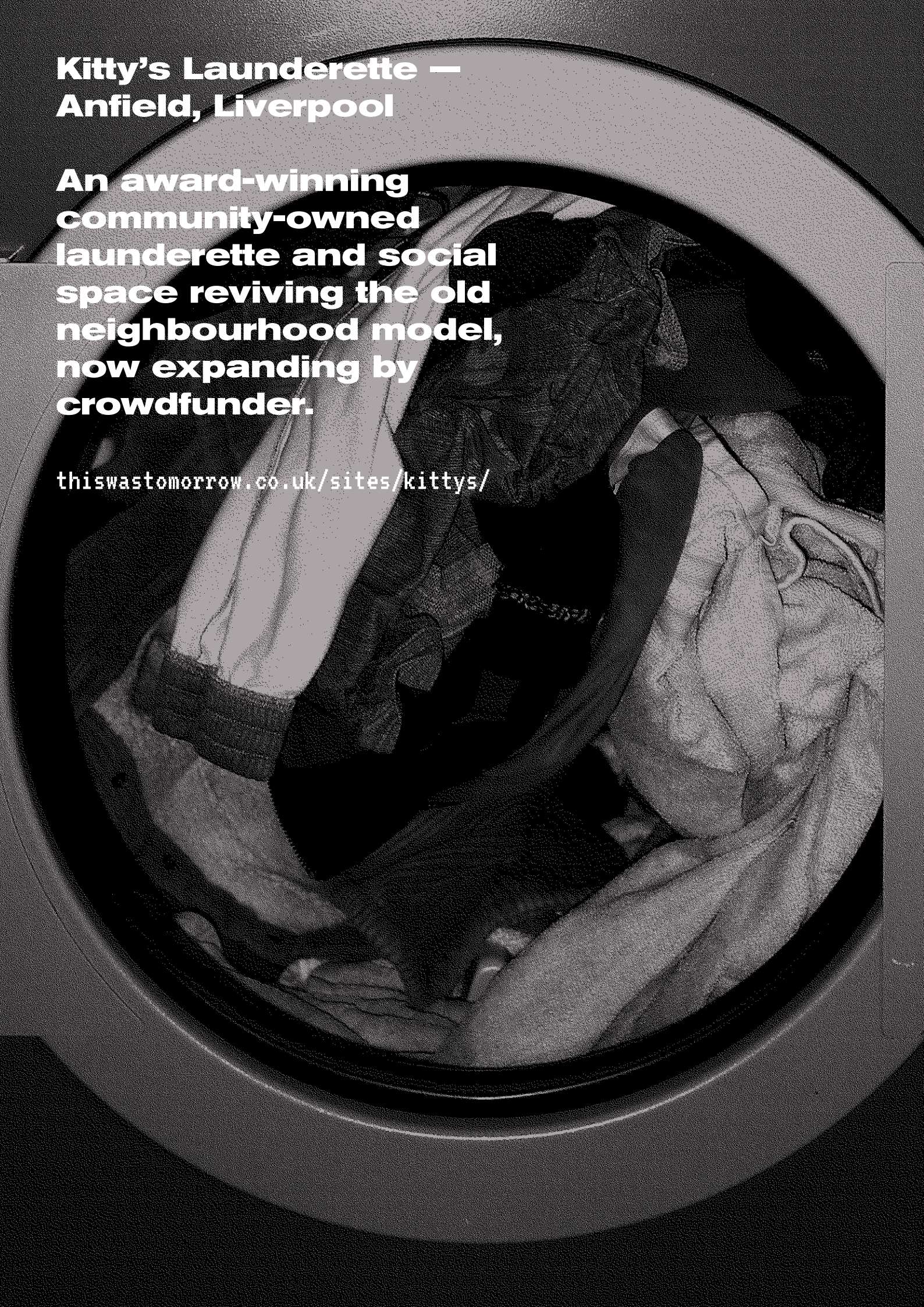
thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/tinkers-bubble/



Kitty's Launderette — Anfield, Liverpool

**An award-winning
community-owned
launderette and social
space reviving the old
neighbourhood model,
now expanding by
crowdfunder.**

thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/kittys/



Two Up Two Down — Anfield, Liverpool

**The new name for Homebaked
Community Land Trust, a
community-led organisation
rooted in Anfield and Everton,
rebuilding a terrace and a high
street around a co-operatively
run bakery. Begun with artist
Jeanne van Heeswijk.**

thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/two-up-two-down/

Granby Four Streets — Liverpool

The Toxteth community land trust - born from a residents' fight against demolition - who took derelict Victorian terraces into community ownership and won the 2015 Turner Prize with the Assemble collective.

thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/granby/

Builds



**Calder Valley
Community Land Trust —
Hebden Bridge & Todmorden**

**A land trust delivering
permanently affordable eco
new build as well as derelict,
reclaimed, retrofitted homes, in
a valley where secure low-rent
housing is scarce.**

thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/calder-valley/

OWCH / New Ground — High Barnet, London

**The UK's first senior
cohousing community, built
by a group of older women
on the site of a former
convent and designed with
them by architects Pollard
Thomas Edwards.**

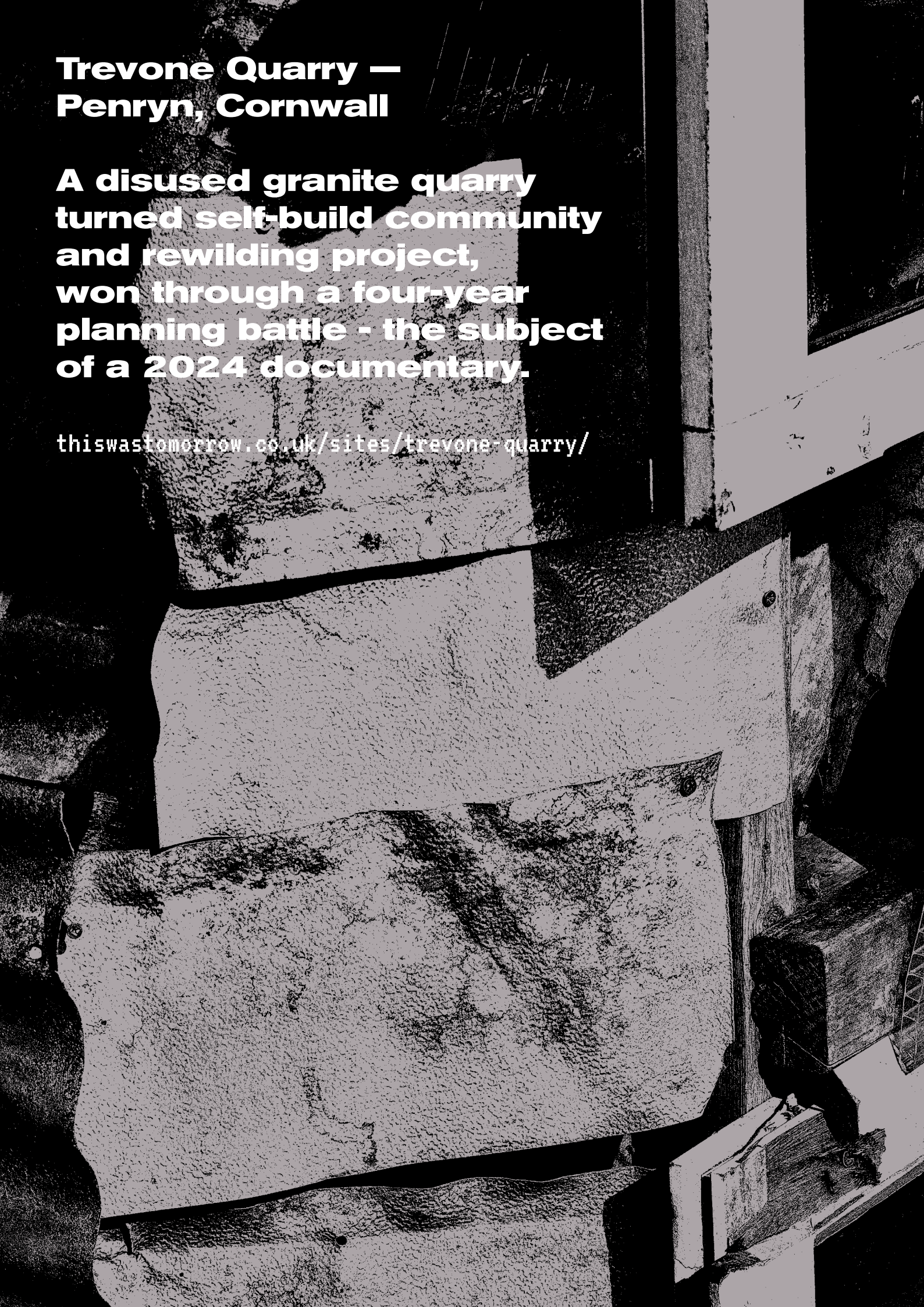
thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/owch-new-ground/



Trevone Quarry — Penryn, Cornwall

**A disused granite quarry
turned self-build community
and rewilding project,
won through a four-year
planning battle - the subject
of a 2024 documentary.**

thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/trevone-quarry/



Kesoberi — Newlyn, Cornwall

**A community farm and housing
co-operative in the making
near Newlyn, in a county where
affordable rural housing has all
but vanished.**

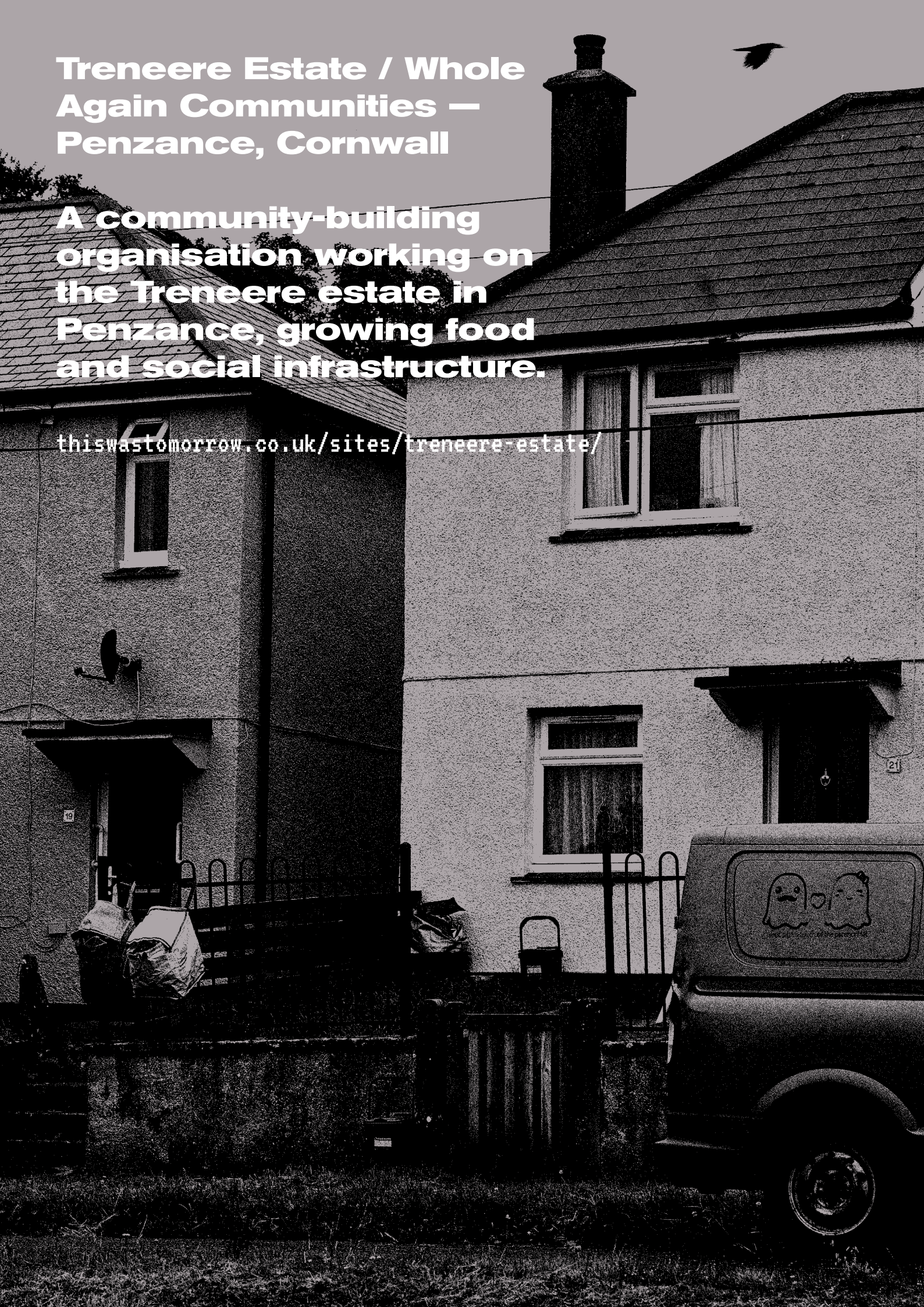
thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/kesoberi-community-farm/



Treneere Estate / Whole Again Communities — Penzance, Cornwall

A community-building organisation working on the Treneere estate in Penzance, growing food and social infrastructure.

thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/treneere-estate/



**LILAC —
Leeds**

**Low Impact Living Affordable
Community: a co-operative
of straw-bale homes with an
income-linked affordability
model, co-founded by urban
geographer Paul Chatterton.**

thiswastomorrow.co.uk/sites/lilac/

UTOPIA